

My Musical Journey

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Piano: discipline and a source of calm

I began learning the piano in primary school and passed the ABRSM Grade 8 piano examination in Grade 7 with a score of 141/150. Years of practice gave me a systematic understanding of music theory and helped me connect that knowledge with the music I played. Working through difficult passages also taught me patience: progress often came from returning to the same challenge, listening carefully, and making small adjustments. As I gradually overcame these difficulties, playing became a source of relaxation and personal satisfaction. Music gave me a way to settle my thoughts and express feelings beyond words.

Clarinet: learning to listen across an orchestra

I started learning the clarinet in the second semester of Grade 6 and joined the Suzhou Youth Symphony Orchestra in Grade 8. My orchestral experiences included performances at the Shanghai Oriental Art Center and, in Grade 10, the National Centre for the Performing Arts in Beijing. Playing alongside other musicians deepened my understanding of how orchestral sections work together. I became more attentive to the relationship between my part and the surrounding sound: when to bring out a melody, when to support another section, and how phrasing and dynamics contribute to a shared interpretation. These experiences made listening an essential part of how I perform.

High school: expression and belonging

In high school, I joined the classical music club, where I continued ensemble playing and practised more solo passages. Solo playing encouraged me to develop my own interpretation and think about how to communicate it to an audience through tone, phrasing, and expression. At the same time, rehearsing with peers gave me a stronger sense of belonging. Sharing the effort of preparing a piece and hearing our individual parts come together made music an important connection between us. Through both solo and ensemble playing, I have found space for personal expression, lasting enjoyment, and a community in which I feel at home.